UPSC Personality Test

“10 Points” for the Interview from the UPSC Chairman, Dr. Ajay Kumar

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The 10 Points (1–5)

1

The will to serve the country comes first

The board checks “whether the young candidate has the mindset to serve the country” (DD News interview, October 2026).

2

Good degrees are not enough

“Not every highly qualified person also wants to do public service.” Show real commitment, not just your CV.

3

Your background has “zero impact”

Hometown, college and socio-economic status do not count. Only your merit on the day is judged.

4

Don't give coached, model-style answers

UPSC is moving away from “the ability to reproduce predictable or coached model answers” (Manthan, 30 Sep 2026).

5

Reasoning over memorisation

Explain why you think something, not just what you think.

The 10 Points (6–10)

6 **Think on the spot**
The board looks at how you handle a question you haven't prepared for.

7 **Show judgment when things are unclear**
Decision-making in uncertain situations — expect situation-based questions.

8 **Stay curious**
“Curiosity is the foundation of civil service.” Tested through hobbies, home state and current events.

9 **Keep a positive, resilient mindset**
“Failures are part of the journey.” Stay calm if a question goes badly.

10 **Keep a sense of perspective**
“Not clearing UPSC is not the end of the world.” Stay steady and be yourself in the room.

● From remarks on the interview ● From his general advice to aspirants

What Is a Public Service Mindset?

A public service mindset means you see a government job as a way to serve citizens, not mainly as a source of power, status or job security.

The test for every decision

Does this make life better for the people I serve, especially those who need it most?



Not mainly about

Power · Status · Job security



It is about

Service · Citizens · The most in need

What It Includes



Citizen first

The public is why the job exists. Files, rules and hierarchy are tools, not ends.



Empathy & compassion

Feel the urgency of the poor and left-out. Gandhi's talisman: recall the poorest face.



Integrity

Honest when no one is watching. No misuse of position for self, kin or the influential.



Accountability

Own results, good and bad. Don't hide behind “the rules didn't allow it.”



Commitment

Over comfort: hard postings, long hours and crises, without complaint.



Impartiality

Caste, religion, region, wealth and political links don't change how you treat anyone.



Problem-solving

Find a way to make things work within the law, not reasons to say no.



Humility

A farmer and a minister get equal respect. Authority is a trust, not an entitlement.

How the Board Checks It in the Interview

“Why civil services?”

Strong: something specific from your own life — an event you saw, a problem you worked on, a gap you want to fix.

Weak: generic lines like “to serve the nation” or “a wide canvas.”

Situation questions

“A flood hits your district and the MLA wants relief sent to his village first.”

They watch whether you put those in greatest need first.

Your DAF

Volunteering, NSS/NCC, community work, or how you handled an earlier job.

All taken as evidence of the mindset.

Your attitude

Against you: arrogance, contempt for politicians or citizens, cynicism about the system.

For you: calm, constructive optimism.



Success is a journey, not a destination

— Arthur Ashe

The process shapes who we are; the outcomes show whether we served anyone.